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Kraft’s ‘solemn ambition’ meets pushback

Blowback over Macklemore ban comes amid commitment to fight antisemitism

By Mark Shanahan and Michael Silverman
GLOBE STAFF

Robert Kraft’s demand that rapper Macklemore be dropped from Ed Sheeran’s tour for expressing pro-Palestinian views has surprised and upset many people, but it’s on-brand for the New England Patriots owner.

In the three decades since he bought the Patriots, rescuing a franchise on the brink of bankruptcy

and winning an improbable six Super Bowls, Kraft has become more than merely the owner of a successful NFL team.

At 85, Kraft is a multimillionaire whose deep political and cultural connections have given him an outsize influence in matters he cares about most. Lately, that’s combating antisemitism. Since 2019, Kraft has committed more than \$100 million to counter what he considers to be

hate speech, and the episode with Macklemore highlights just how far he’ll go to confront what he perceives to be anti-Jewish bigotry.

When the Seattle rapper yelled “Free Palestine!” from a stage in New Jersey on Sept. 4, there were scattered calls by pro-Israel groups for Sheeran to remove Macklemore as his opening act. But nothing happened until Kraft got involved.

In separate phone calls to Sheeran and the promoter of the singer’s shows next week at Gillette, the Patriots owner said Macklemore would not be welcome in Foxbor-

ough due to his statements in New Jersey and “a broader history of antisemitic rhetoric and imagery that has been deeply offensive and hurtful to the Jewish community.” Further, according to a message posted by Macklemore, Kraft “rallied” owners of other venues on Sheeran’s tour to ban the rapper. (The Wall Street Journal reported that David Tepper, Arthur Blank, and Jeffrey Lurie — owners of the Carolina Panthers, Atlanta Falcons, and Philadelphia Eagles — were the first NFL owners to fall in line.)

KRAFT, Page A7

Trump confounds party’s prospects

He draws attention to his unpopular policies as GOP braces for midterms

By Jim Puzzanghera, Tal Kopan, and Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — As President Trump delivered a campaign speech in North Carolina on Wednesday night, he spent some time speaking about the three Republican candidates he was there to support. But mostly he talked up everything he’s done in his second term on the economy, immigration, and foreign affairs.

And that, for many Republicans, could be the problem.

The party of the incumbent president typically faces headwinds in a midterm election. But many polls show Republicans are headed for a wipeout this November, spurred on by Trump’s unpopular policies and the spotlight he keeps shining on them.

The president has dismissed concerns about cost of living issues and the impact of artificial intelligence as “hoaxes.” His war with Iran has sent gas prices skyrocketing and dragged the US into a conflict with no clear end in sight — violating two of Trump’s most explicit promises from the 2024 campaign. His global trade war has added to inflation pressures, and his new round of tariffs on Canada hit particularly hard in two states, Maine and Michigan, that have pivotal Senate races this November.

And while Americans struggle with higher consumer prices, Trump has spent large amounts of his time focused on reshaping Washington in his image by constructing a lavish new ballroom at the White House and obsessing over a proposed

TRUMP, Page A6



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Third-grader Deema Elkhadir played during recess at the Tobin Montessori School in Cambridge this month.

Getting serious about play time for students

Citing need for downtime, group pushes for expanded recess

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

CAMBRIDGE — A handful of times a day, groups of kids at the Baldwin School trudge across the crosswalk to the Alden Play Area to kick balls on a blacktop or scale a spider-web of ropes to a long, snaking slide. Or they head to a field where they can play tag, or simply walk with friends in the fresh air.

There is no curriculum. No tally of math and reading scores to consider. No screens. And unless someone sprains a wrist, not much adult intervention.

It’s recess, carrying on just as it was in the days before ChatGPT, Chromebooks, and the MCAS.

But according to many parents and an activist movement making gains in Massachusetts and across the country, children aren’t getting nearly enough of it.

In Massachusetts, there are no rules for how often it must happen, or for how long. Here in Cambridge, recess is about 25 minutes on average, but experts said that statewide, some elementary school kids only get 15.

Now there is an effort to change that, even at the expense of the ultra-optimized classrooms state leaders have been trying to create to boost slumping test scores.

“We mistake more for better. So it’s like, ‘Let’s spend more time on literacy instruc-

tion, and that’ll equate to more learning,’” said Emma Pascarella, the leader of the Massachusetts chapter of Say Yes to Recess, a nationwide advocacy group. “But downtime is an important part of processing as well.”

In the past year and a half, the organization has set up chapters in 23 states and is pushing an ambitious corrective: an entire hour of recess.

In Tennessee, the group won a minimum of 40 minutes of recess in elementary schools, up from just 15.

In Massachusetts, a bill gaining traction would mandate a minimum of 30 “consecutive minutes of supervised, safe, and unstruc-

RECESS, Page A10

Healey promised action. Here’s what’s happened.

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Four years ago, Governor Maura Healey pledged to usher in a new era of Democratic leadership, aggressively tackle the climate crisis, and “build an economy in which everyone can thrive.”

Now, as she runs for reelection against a well-funded Republican challenger, voters must determine whether Healey has kept her promises in deciding whether to give her another term.

The Globe reviewed a slew of pledges Healey made in 2022 during debates, in dozens of news releases, and in media interviews, and compared them with her track record.

The results: Healey, 55, has delivered on some and broken others, and

many appear to be works in progress as she prepares to face Republican nominee Michael Minogue on Nov. 3.

PROMISE: Cut taxes.

FINDING: Promise kept.

In her first campaign ad, Healey said she would “cut taxes.” Months later, in the final gubernatorial debate with then-Republican nominee Geoff Diehl, Healey again zeroed in on taxes when asked how she would ease economic pain.

“Cutting taxes,” she responded. “Cutting taxes.”

She did, roughly nine months into her term, when she signed a \$1 billion tax package that was billed as the state’s first significant tax cut in two decades. The law slashed the tax rate on short-term capital gains —

HEALEY, Page A5

Kennedy family decries threats to arts center

Rebukes Trump for ‘small-minded’ actions

By Chris Van Buskirk, Samantha J. Gross, and Camilo Fonseca
GLOBE STAFF

and Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Members of the Kennedy family sounded off on President Trump on Thursday, accusing him of holding the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts “hostage” and trying to appropriate the memory of the late president by pushing to have his own name added to the Washington institution.

Trump “seems to be focused on trying to appropriate the legacy rather than serving the people that he was elected to serve,” former US representative Joseph Kennedy III, a great-nephew of the late president and a grandson of Robert F. Kennedy, said in a phone interview. “That, ultimately, is going to be a legacy that he’s going to have to wrestle with.”

Kennedy joined other members of his family in sharply criticizing Trump’s push to add his name to the performing arts center; on Tuesday Kerry Kennedy, daughter of Robert F. Kennedy, said the closure amounted to “hostage taking” by Trump.

Another Kennedy family member, Jack Schlossberg, a former congressional hopeful, dis-

KENNEDYS, Page A6



BRENDAN SMIALOWSKI/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

President Trump viewed a poster board titled “Kennedy Center Demolished” aboard Air Force One on Wednesday.



Sun of mine

Friday: Sunny, pleasant. High: 77-82. Low: 53-58.
Saturday: Cooler, some clouds. High: 62-67. Low: 52-57.
Sunrise: 6:27 Sunset: 6:49
Comics and Weather, **G6-7**.
Obituaries, **C9**.

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00

A gene mutation has been found to make lung cancer 62 times as likely in those who have never smoked and 10 times as likely in smokers. A2.

The Trump administration has approved visas for top Iranian officials to attend next week’s UN General Assembly high-level meeting in New York. **A3.**

A MetroWest school district found itself the target of a federal investigation after the removal of a student by a state agency gained attention in conservative media circles this week. **B1.**

The once politically progressive Rhode Island news site Uprise RI has become an automated site with human-looking avatars disguised as reporters. **B5.**



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